Ten Thousand Stories – A Collection

By Margaret Walker, Amanda Gorman and Lebohang Masango

For My People by Margaret Walker

For my people everywhere singing their slave songs repeatedly: their dirges and their ditties and their blues and jubilees, praying their prayers nightly to an unknown god, bending their knees humbly to an unseen power;

For my people lending their strength to the years, to the gone years and the now years and the maybe years, washing ironing cooking scrubbing sewing mending hoeing plowing digging planting pruning patching dragging along never gaining never reaping never knowing and never understanding . . .

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INTRODUCTION

Margaret Walker wrote the poem, "For My People," in 1937 – almost 100 years ago. She addresses the history of African American slavery; the racism endured by people of color and the hope for a better future ***her*** *people,* ***my*** *people manage to keep alive despite the odds stacked against them. You see, even then . . . stories mattered.*

History is a story; culture is a story – stories told by many different people from many different perspectives. Listen . . . there is ***always*** *a story. Stories that engage, inspire, heal and, just perhaps, bring humanity together to forge a better future. Stories are what we remember.*

Ten Thousand Stories – A Collection containing For My People by Margaret Walker, New Day's Lyric by Amanda Gorman and Ten Thousand Stories by Lebohang Masango

For the cramped bewildered years we went to school to learn to know the reasons why and the answers to and the people who and the places where and the days when, in memory of the bitter hours when we discovered we were black and poor and small and different and nobody cared and nobody wondered and nobody understood;

For the boys and girls who grew in spite of these things to be man and woman, to laugh and dance and sing and

play and drink their wine and religion and success, to
marry their playmates and bear children and then die
of consumption and anemia and lynching;

For my people thronging 47th Street in Chicago and Lenox
Avenue in New York and Rampart Street in New
Orleans, lost disinherited dispossessed and happy
people filling the cabarets and taverns and other
people's pockets needing bread and shoes and milk and
land and money and something—something all our own;

For my people standing staring trying to fashion a better
way
from confusion, from hypocrisy and misunderstanding,
trying to fashion a world that will hold all the people,
all the faces, all the adams and eves and their countless
generations;

Let a new earth rise. Let another world be born , , , Let a
second generation full of courage issue forth; let a people
loving freedom come to growth. Let a beauty full of
healing and a strength of final clenching be the pulsing
in our spirits and our blood. Let the martial songs
be written, let the dirges disappear. . . [For this is a]

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Margaret Walker
Book: This is My Century: New and Collected Poems, Pg 6-7
ISBN: 978-0820345970
Publisher: University of Georgis Press
Date (Month/Year): Oct 2013

Also available on-line at:
https://poets.org/poem/my-people

AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier
This poem only, paired with
I Hear a Rumbling by Margaret Walker

New Day's Lyric by Amanda Gorman

May this be the day
We come together.
Mourning, we come to mend,
Withered, we come to weather,
Torn, we come to tend,
Battered, we come to better.
Tethered by this year of yearning,
We are learning
That though we weren't ready for this,
We have been readied by it.

NATIONAL USE ONLY

We steadily vow that no matter
How we are weighed down,
We must always pave a way forward.
*
This hope is our door, our portal.
Even if we never get back to normal,
Someday we can venture beyond it,
To leave the known and take the first steps.
So let us not return to what was normal,
But reach toward what is next.
*
What was cursed, we will cure.
What was plagued, we will prove pure.
Where we tend to argue, we will try to agree,
Those fortunes we forswore, now the future we foresee,
Where we weren't aware, we're now awake;
Those moments we missed
Are now these moments we make,
The moments we meet,
And our hearts, once all together beaten,
Now all together beat.
*

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Come, look up with kindness yet,
For even solace can be sourced from sorrow.
We remember, not just for the sake of yesterday,
But to take on tomorrow.
*
We heed this old spirit,
In a new day's lyric,
In our hearts, we hear it:
For auld lang syne, my dear,
For auld lang syne.
Be bold, sang Time this year,
Be bold, sang Time,
For when you honor yesterday,
Tomorrow ye will find.
Know what we've fought
Need not be forgot nor for none.
It defines us, binds us as one,
Come over, join this day just begun.
For wherever we come together,
We will forever overcome.
[Because]

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Amanda Gorman
ISBN: On-line Transcript
https://www.newsweek.com/read-amanda-gorman-new-years-poem-new-days-lyric-full-1664343
Publisher: Newsweek.com
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Ten Thousand Stories by Lebohang Masango

I come as one, but I stand as 10 000 stories

10 000 journeys of

Flesh, heartbeat, voice, breath

Bloodlines running like rivers wild

Vessels of DNA criss-crossing this continent

As I stand firmly in the soil of my origin

I carry the hopes of Africa in my chest

And our defiant elders in my lungs

And we have always lived with our hearts towards the sky

We, phoenix-like rise, to new heights

Cradling the aspirations and dreams

Of our beautiful children

The visions of every little one

With imaginations as precious

And as agile as rain

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Cradling waves of our narrative lineages

From the beginning to the present

Our stories are embellished on the great wings

Of tomorrow

So, when I speak, I do so as one, but I come as many

Because conjuring purpose and passion from pain

Has always been our people's true alchemy

When we are all gone

These testaments will remain

The future ones will know us by our works of heart;

Our living art

Time will stand tall and bear witness to us in all

Our glory

Our beginning, middle and end

Is commanded by a spirit greater than anything

We have ever known

So, tell *your* story

Shout it from the rooftops

To the mountaintops

Let it reverberate through the universe

Take up space in places you have never been

Occupy new worlds

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Stare down the sky and let them know that you

intend to leave this world as you came. . .

A collective kind of unconquerable

We come as one, but we stand as 10,000 stories

10 000 journeys of

Flesh

Heartbeat

Voice

Breath

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lebohang Masango
ISBN: On-line Transcript
https://lebohangmasango.com/2021/05/21/ten-thousand-stories/
Publisher: Published by the Author
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Video can be viewed here:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UxFymU4R31U

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